The Scopes Trial: Darrow Examines Bryan

Clarence Darrow & William Jennings Bryan · July 20, 1925

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> In the Scopes "Monkey Trial," defense attorney Clarence Darrow put prosecutor and Bible expert William Jennings Bryan on the stand, exposing tensions between literal readings of Scripture and modern science in a landmark clash of the 1920s culture wars.

Bryan takes the stand

Darrow—On scientific matters, Col. Bryan can speak for himself.

Bryan—If your honor please, I insist that Mr. Darrow can be put on the stand, and Mr. Malone and Mr. Hays.

The Court—Call anybody you desire. Ask them any questions you wish.

[. . .]

Darrow questions Bryan on the Bible and Jonah

Q—You have given considerable study to the Bible, haven't you, Mr. Bryan?

A—Yes, sir, I have tried to.

Q—Then you have made a general study of it?

A—Yes, I have; I have studied the Bible for about fifty years, or sometime more than that, but, of course, I have studied it more as I have become older than when I was but a boy.

Q—You claim that everything in the Bible should be literally interpreted?

A—I believe everything in the Bible should be accepted as it is given there: some of the Bible is given illustratively. For instance: "Ye are the salt of the earth." I would not insist that man was actually salt, or that he had flesh of salt, but it is used in the sense of salt as saving God's people.

Q—But when you read that Jonah swallowed the whale—or that the whale swallowed Jonah— excuse me please—how do you literally interpret that?

A—When I read that a big fish swallowed Jonah—it does not say whale....That is my recollection of it. A big fish, and I believe it, and I believe in a God who can make a whale and can make a man and make both what He pleases. . . .

Q—But do you believe He made them—that He made such a fish and that it was big enough to swallow Jonah?

A—Yes, sir. Let me add: One miracle is just as easy to believe as another

Q—Just as hard?

A—It is hard to believe for you, but easy for me. A miracle is a thing performed beyond what man can perform. When you get within the realm of miracles; and it is just as easy to believe the miracle of Jonah as any other miracle in the Bible.

Q—Perfectly easy to believe that Jonah swallowed the whale?

A—If the Bible said so; the Bible doesn't make as extreme statements as evolutionists do....

[. . .]

On the Flood and the date of creation

Q—You believe the story of the flood to be a literal interpretation?

A—Yes, sir.

Q—When was that Flood?

A—I would not attempt to fix the date. The date is fixed, as suggested this morning.

Q—About 4004 B.C.?

A—That has been the estimate of a man that is accepted today. I would not say it is accurate. . . .

Q—What do you think?
A—I do not think about things I don't think about.
Q—Do you think about things you do think about?
A—Well, sometimes. (Laughter in the courtyard.)

[. . .]

On the age of the earth

Q—Do you think the earth was made in six days?
A—Not six days of twenty-four hours.
Q—Doesn't it say so?
A—No, sir.... . . .
Bryan—The reason I am answering is not for the benefit of the superior court. It is to keep these gentlemen from saying I was afraid to meet them and let them question me, and I want the Christian world to know that any atheist, agnostic, unbeliever, can question me anytime as to my belief in God, and I will answer him. . . .
Q—You think those were not literal days?
A—I do not think they were twenty-four-hour days.
Q—What do you think about it?
A—That is my opinion—I do not know that my opinion is better on that subject than those who think it does.
Q—You do not think that ?
A—No. But I think it would be just as easy for the kind of God we believe in to make the earth in six days as in six years or in 6,000,000 years or in 600,000,000 years. I do not think it important whether we believe one or the other.
Q—Do you think those were literal days?
A—My impression is they were periods, but I would not attempt to argue as against anybody who wanted to believe in literal days.

[. . .]

Bryan, on Darrow's purpose

Bryan—Your Honor, I think I can shorten this testimony. The only purpose Mr. Darrow has is to slur at the Bible, but I will answer his question. I will answer it all at once, and I have no objection in the world, I want the world to know that this man, who does not believe in a God, is trying to use a court in Tennesseee—
Darrow—I object to that.
Bryan—(Continuing) to slur at it, and while it will require time, I am willing to take it.
Darrow—I object to your statement. I am exempting you on your fool ideas that no intelligent Christian on earth believes.
The Court—Court is adjourned until 9 o'clock tomorrow morning.

Words to know

literally interpreted — read as exactly true in every detail, not as symbol or story

illustratively — as a figure of speech or illustration, not a literal fact

evolutionists — people who accept Darwin's theory of evolution

agnostic — someone who says we cannot know whether God exists

slur — insult or discredit

adjourned — paused the court session until later